1991, met with all Shia Mujahideen factions in Tehran to see if there was any convergence of interests. This meeting took place before Najibullah's fall and, to the diplomat's surprise, 'a lot was common in their and our thinking about Afghanistan and its politics and security ... we shared a lot of perceptions and built upon them after that'.[86] Given that overt governmental contacts with such figures could have posed political problems or embarrassment to both India and Najibullah, these links were kept secret. Some such links were also facilitated by Indian academics and journalists—a practice that India followed well into the post-2001 phase when engaging with the Afghan Taliban.

An emerging conciliator, it was clear to Dixit that Islamabad was unable to secure control either over Rabbani, Massoud, or even Hekmatyar. This assessment was critical in shaping the conciliator's policy approach and advocating engagement. While the conciliators agreed that the Mujahideen (and later the Taliban) were sponsored by the ISI, they did not see these groups as being remotely controlled by Pakistan. Moreover, opening channels with the Mujahideen was also an imperative to revive the inflow of critical intelligence related to the Punjab and Kashmir insurgencies that R&AW received from the erstwhile KhAD, which had dried up after Najibullah's fall.[87] According to B. Raman, a senior R&AW officer who had helped open a channel with the royalists in 1985, the Mujahideen were hurt and disappointed by India's pro-Najibullah tilt and New Delhi's reluctance to support the Mujahideen's struggle against the Soviet occupation. But such feelings did not turn the Mujahideen 'hostile to India'.[88] Many Afghan Mujahideen leaders 'maintained secret contacts with the R&AW even while cooperating with the ISI and the CIA against the Soviet troops in Afghanistan', claimed Raman. Rajiv had supported this covert angle to his Afghanistan policy, but only to a limited extent. All the three R&AW chiefs from Indira Gandhi's time to that of Rajiv, that is G. C. Saxena, S. E. Joshi, and A. K. Verma, had followed a triangular strategy towards Pakistan that is 'co-operative relations where possible, hard-hitting covert actions where necessary, and close networking with Afghanistan'.[89] Rao, allegedly, altered this strategy.

Even though Pakistani sources dispute Rao's mild approach given R&AW's continued links with the Mujahideen, Rao did reduce, if not abandon, the lethal angle to India's covert action in Afghanistan and Pakistan.[90] Vikram Sood, former